

The Path To Toondom

The traditional path would be to graduate in Fine Arts from a school such as Mumbai's JJ School Of Arts and apply for a trainee position. India's premier design school, the National Institute of Design (NID) Ahmedabad, has a two-year post graduate course in Animation Film Design. Entrants typically have to be graduates in Fine Arts, Applied Arts, Design, Architecture, Communication Media, Film & TV, or Mass Media, or graduates with experience in the animation Industry. But with just 10 seats in the program, competition is fierce.

Akhil Succena, activity chairperson, education, NID, says, "Since this is a post-graduate course, we expect some level of proficiency. An applicant has to present a portfolio as part of the admission process. This criteria leads to people already working in the sector such as 'in-betweeners' and others to apply." According to Mr Succena, an NID animation diploma holder typically starts off at a salary of Rs 30,000 per month.

For a beginner, options include private institutions such as Arena and Zee Institute of Creative Arts (ZICA). According to Atul Vohra, country head, Arena Multimedia, "The animation industry has a current requirement of at least 50,000 trained persons. Only 20 per cent of this is presently fulfilled. This translates into almost 100 per cent placement and entry-level salaries of Rs 10,000 per month." We ask Vohra about what makes a skilled animator. "The ability to express oneself through drawings and acting is the fundamental requirement. Computers only provide a tool."

According to Mr Vohra, getting carried away by the "cool factor" associated with animation is easy. But success in the field needs talent and application. The two Arena training centres in Mumbai have only 40 seats each, and every applicant undergoes a screening process before being admitted. 2D animation is covered in the first year and 3D follows suit. The course fees of 1.8 lakh per annum also might deter the casual hobbyist.

And it's not all software training, either. About 50 per cent of the classes are on drawing, anatomy, study of motion, acting and cinematography. Software such as Toon Boom, Solo for 2D, and 3DMax and Maya for 3D follow. Composition is taught on Combustion, while Flash and Photoshop complete the package.

In a typical animation set up, the roles include the storyboard artist, audio specialist, character designer, background artist, in-betweeners and the key animator. Of these, the key animator designs the first and last frames of a 24 fps sequence. "In-betweeners" fill in the gaps. While students at Arena are exposed to every function during a course to figure out what fits them best, Mr. Vohra recommends the talented ones to focus on the role of Key Animator.

A Reality Check

Many institutes also offer shorter six-month module-based courses which, though cheaper, may also be riskier. Be warned that in a country



“Software are just tools. Anyone can learn to use them. The essence is to have the inherent creative talent to be able to use those tools to create works of art”

Rajesh Pai
Technical director
Rhythm & Hues Studios

like ours, the demand-supply equation is tilted in the direction of the employer. A typical example is that of Sindhu Nair from Mumbai, quoted in a *Wired News* article:

"Nair's father owns a small shop in Mumbai. Although he earns about Rs 11,000 every month, he had great dreams for his 22-year-old daughter, Sindhu. After reading countless articles in the papers, he was sold on the great IT revolution. He borrowed money and paid about Rs 31,000 for a six-month animation course.

"Nair completed the course, but spent another eight months looking for employment before finally landing a job in the field that pays Rs 900 per month."

The Industry-Side Story

When *The Lion, the Witch and the Wardrobe* was nominated for an Academy Award in visual effects, there was rejoicing in the Mumbai subsidiary of the California-based animation studio, Rhythm 'n' Hues, because part of the animation process was completed here. We asked Rajesh Pai, technical director, about what this means for the sector in general and jobs in particular. His answer: "The visual effects industry, though at a very nascent stage in India as compared to the global scenario, is witnessing rapid growth. Naturally, there will be an increased demand for talent to meet the requirements." As for the areas of critical requirement, says Mr Pai, "By its very nature, this work requires talented individuals with a background in art and with creative sensibilities.

"While most people only see the opportunities in the artistic field, very few people consider the technological challenges that this industry presents. All this creative magic—animation, visual effects—would not be possible without the amazing technology behind it. The requirement for technical people is equally, if not more, critical for the industry. There is definitely a demand for technology professionals, both on the hardware as well as the software side. We, at Rhythm & Hues Studios for example, are a totally Linux-based facility. We are constantly on the lookout for Linux professionals to grow our technology team."

From an industry perspective, Mr. Pai says that irrespective of one's training, it has become an accepted norm that resources need to be trained and developed in-house for them to be productive in a real-life production environment. The key factor, therefore, in selecting candidates, is the spark of intelligence and passion.



Animation Schools Teach...

Editing

Avid
Final Cut Pro

3D

Softimage XSI
MAYA
Autodesk-3DxMax

Visual Effects

Combustion
Adobe AfterFX
Digital fusion
Flame

Image Editing

Adobe Photoshop